

Michael's Brief Guide to Dungeons & Dragons 5th Edition

Character Creation in a Nutshell

Characters can be created in a variety of ways, but the following is the easiest way I have found:

1. **Choose a Race** - This is your character's heritage. Almost all races found in the game have two or more subraces to pick from, giving lots of variety to a character.
2. **Choose a Class** - This is your character's role or job as an adventurer. There are 12 classes to pick from, and each of those offers multiple paths of skills and abilities to follow, offering even more variety to pick from.
3. **Roll your Ability Scores** - Using dice, roll your ability scores and pick how to distribute them to your character based on your race, class, and character concept.
4. **Describe your Character** - How tall is your character? What color hair to they have? Where did they grow up? How did they come to be who they are? All these kinds of questions can be answered here. Don't fret if you don't have it all figured out yet; sometimes answers to these questions are discovered while playing!
5. **Pick your Equipment** - What weapons, armor, and/or items does your character use and travel with? Based on your class and character concept, choose from a large variety to give your character an edge while adventuring.

On the following pages, I will go into greater detail about each of these steps and categories. There is a lot to this game, but I will be with you the whole way. Don't forget to ask me questions!

RACES

Listed here are summaries of each of the races'--and their subraces'--abilities and physical descriptions.

AARAKOCRA

Aarakocra are fierce bird-like warriors that hail from the Elemental Plane of Air. Resembling eagles or falcons, their large wings give them the unique ability to fly without magic. They are agile and wise, and can adeptly defend themselves with incredibly sharp talons.

AASIMAR

Aasimar are those born with angelic or divine blood in them. They appear as wonderfully gorgeous humans, with fair and light colored features. They can see in the dark, and resist both good and evil divine energy. Thier mystic blood allows them the heal minor wounds, and make objects glow on command.

- **Fallen Aasimar** have succumbed to darker powers, and can instill fear in creatures surrounding them.
- **Protector Aasimar** are sometimes mistaken for angels on earth. They have the ability to grow wings of pure light for a short time.
- **Scourge Aasimar** are warriors of wrath. They can burst into flame and damage surrounding foes.

BUGBEAR

Bugbears are hulking, hairy, creatures with fierce reputations for war and bloodshed. Their long limbs allow them to reach targets beyond that of normal creatures, and they can see in darkness with eases. They excel at sneaking up on opponents and striking with swiftness.

DRAGONBORN

Dragonborn are said to have descended from the gods themselves, and usually live near-immortal lives because of their magical lineage. They stand much taller than humans, at an average of 8 feet, and appear to be large, bipedal lizards. Dragonborn clans mean more than life itself, and will do anything to protect whatever they hold dear. A dragonborn's heritage can easily be determined by the color of its scales. Having draconic ancestry allows them a special attack determined by the color of dragon they come from. Their scales also give them an advantage in physical defenses.

- **Black:** Acid
- **Blue:** Lightning
- **Brass:** Fire
- **Bronze:** Lightning
- **Copper:** Acid
- **Gold:** Fire
- **Green:** Poison
- **Red:** Fire
- **Silver:** Cold
- **White:** Cold

DWARF

Dwarves are stout, hearty folk. Males sport wonderfully coiffed facial hair, and females are rumored to do the same. Their clans and heritage are found in mountain citadels and cavern cities. They know their way around minerals, gems, and mines. Dwarves possess increased resilience, can see in the dark, and can identify stonework with incredibly accuracy.

- **Duergar** are gray-skinned dwarves that live exclusively underground in deep cavern cities. They are stronger than any other dwarves, and possess some magical abilities, but are sensitive to the harsh light of the sun.
- **Hill Dwarves** possess keen senses and deep intuition, as well as increased vitality.
- **Mountain Dwarves** are stronger than their hill kin, and train in personal defenses.

ELF

Elves are a near-immortal race of magical creatures. With iconic pointy ears, slender frame and features, and large eyes, they are easy to identify in a crowd. With an affinity for nature, their magical lineages connect them to the world in ways others cannot understand. Elves are flexible and move elegantly, can see in the dark, and their ears and eyes give them heightened senses. Their magical roots protect them from some effects, and allows them to meditate instead of sleeping.

- **Drow** are rarer in the overworld, living exclusively in deep underground cities and abhorring the light. They carry a reputation of being cultist and evil masterminds, and as such tend to be looked down on and have more reactionary personalities. They can see long distances in darkness, but their large eyes are sensitive to the light of the overworld sun. They also possess innate magical abilities.
- **Eladrin** are elves that come from a mystical realm called the Feywild. They are touched with special abilities and physical traits tied to nature and the seasons (Autumn, Winter, Spring, and Summer), and tend to be more pleasing to the eye.
- **High Elves** study the world around them, giving them a deeper intelligence of life and magic.
- **Sea Elves** come from deep civilizations in the ocean. They swim with perfection and are amphibious, and can converse with aquatic creatures.
- **Shadar-Kai** are elves from a mysterious realm called the Shadowfell. They resist the chills of death more readily, and can become shadow for brief periods of time.
- **Wood Elves** possess more wits than their studious counterparts. Special hunting training allows them to move faster, as well as hide in certain natural conditions.

FIRBOLG

Firbolg are mountain and forest dwelling giant folk. Large and gentle, they are caretakers of nature. They see the world, and everything in it, as beauties to be cherished, studied, and improved. They have innate magical abilities, including the gift of invisibility to keep their secrets safe, and the ability to speak with both animals and plant life.

GENASI

Descended from genies of the various Elemental Planes, the Genasi are rarities and wonders seldom seen on earth. Their elemental lineage allows them to live much longer and survive harsher situations than most other creatures.

- **Air Genasi** are descended from djinn. They can be calm and serene or wild and violent, just as the winds from which they are born. They are agile as a breeze, and can float in the air on command.
- **Earth Genasi** are descended from dao. They ponder choices long and hard before making one, and are able to keep emotions in check with simplicity. They are strong and stalwart, and can meld themselves with earthy terrains.
- **Fire Genasi** are descended from efreet. They tend to be impatient and make rash decisions, often resulting in personal gain and/or violence. They are smart tacticians who understand the importance of quick thinking, and can call upon their seething anger to create fire from nothing.
- **Water Genasi** are descended from marid. They are fiercely independent and can easily adapt to any situation thrown at them. They are quick-witted, and can breathe both water and air. Their elemental heritage allows them the ability to bend water to their will.

GITH

Gith are beings from the Outer Planes of existence. They travel through space and time to other planes and dimensions to accomplish their goals, both noble and nefarious. They are highly intelligent beings. Two groups of Gith dominate the Outer Planes, their differences being mostly how they view the universe.

- **Githyanki** are constantly on a war campaign to explore, enslave, and dominate the farthest reaches of the universe. They train as skilled warriors to help accomplish this goal, and have unique psychic abilities that complement their skills.
- **Githzerai** see the universe as a means to ultimate knowledge. They use their superior intellect and wits to observe and learn from both friends and foes. They possess unique psychic abilities to assist in this endeavor.

GNOME

Gnomes are the busy-bodies of the world. They are given a purpose or goal in life at birth, and they spend the rest of their existence trying to accomplish it. They are a larger part of the world's small folk, standing at about 3' 6" on average. They are always trying to further the collective knowledge of the world, and often find themselves inventing new ways to do so, and teaching others what they have learned. Gnomes travel to all kinds of terrains, and have adapted to see in the dark as a result. All their knowledge and research of how things work in the world offers them protections against certain magical effects.

- **Forest Gnomes** have a natural penchant for creating illusions to trick other creatures. They are also incredibly agile. Living so long in the forest, they have also gained the ability to communicate with small animals.
- **Rock Gnomes** are hardier and possess more vitality. With increased knowledge of magic items, alchemical creations, and mechanical devices, they spend much of their time creating ways to assist with their pursuit of their life goal.
- **Sverfneblin** are gnomes that live in deep caves. They are quick and agile, can hide very well in rocky terrain, and can see incredibly far in darkness.

GOBLIN

Goblins are small, greedy, and cowardly folk. Their agile ways and small size give them a great advantage in combat against larger, slower enemies. Their natural abilities to see in the darkness, or hide and run from danger keep them alive longer than others.

GOLIATH

Goliaths are fierce warriors descended from the oldest giants of the world. Some see them as barbaric tribes of ruthless murderers, but others view them as noble wild folk who prefer the nomadic ways of old. They boast superior strength and vitality, natural athleticism, and can shrug off wounds as if they were nothing.

HALF-ELF

While mixed race people are fairly common among the world, Half-Elf is one of the most common. They are often seen as diplomats or envoys between their respective lineages; they tend to be seen as more amenable versions of elves. They can see in the dark as well as their elven kin. They have retained some of their elven kin's magical defenses, and are quick to master skills like their human ancestors.

HALF-ORC

The other most common mixed race people are Half-Orcs. Traditionally, they are born out of the pillage and rape of a village by tribes of barbaric orcs. However, many Half-Orcs have gained a foothold in modern society in the recent centuries. Half-Orcs possess a range of physical traits depending on how far removed they are from their orcish kin. They usually possess an affinity for physical exertion, as well as increased vitality. Like their orcish ancestors, they can see in the dark and tend towards intense (negatively) personalities. They also have the ability to keep fighting when others would fall in battle.

HALFLING

Halflings are small folk, standing an average of 3' tall. They are a jovial people and overly curious about "tall folk", and take loyalty to absolute extremes. It is almost a rite of passage that a halfling spend some portion of their life adventuring and exploring the world, but they are incredibly adept at adapting to any culture they find themselves in. Being small in stature, halflings are incredibly agile. No matter what circumstances they find themselves in, they always seem to have a stroke of luck at just the right time, and often stare adversity in its deadly face.

- **Lightfoot Halflings** are the most common of the small folk to be seen wandering the world. They are quick to make friends and carry very positive dispositions. They do tend to find themselves in unwarranted trouble, and as such have adapted to hiding and sneaking rather well.
- **Stout Halflings** are hardier than their kin, able to withstand pain more readily, and have a genetic resistance to poisons of all kinds.

HOBGOBLIN

Hobgoblins are larger versions of their small goblinoid kin. They are heartier and more intelligent than other monstrous races, but are seen as grotesque or deformed humans by ancient curses. Their society emphasizes martial prowess and combat training, and they are skilled at hiding emotions while fighting.

HUMAN

Humans are the most common, and most versatile and adaptable, race of the overworld. They come in a large variety of backgrounds, lineages, and physical appearances.

KENKU

The raven-like people known as Kenku are mysterious folk. With no language of their own, they can only mimic the voices and sounds of other creatures they have heard. This lends well to being spies and sneaks in the service of other people. It is surmised that they were cursed long ago to be flightless birds for some grave transgression against a god. They are quick in both body and mind, and can impeccably mimic voices, sounds, and handwriting.

KOBOLD

Kobolds are small dragon-like creatures. They live in large tribes and families, preferring to live as servants to an enemy than die by an enemy's sword. They know how to take advantage of being close to allies in combat, but living in subterranean systems so long has rendered them vulnerable to sunlight.

LIZARDFOLK

The Lizardfolk commonly seen around waterways and swamps are known to seek adventure as a rite of passage. They are simple, tribal folk, and tend to shun (and be shunned by) modern society. They can expertly swim any body of water, use their toothy maws to attack foes, and their hunter knowledge gives them an edge in survival and gathering resources. The scales on their body also provide defenses as if it was armor.

ORC

Great tribes of Orc warriors roam the land, taking what they want and warring with most they come across. They are strong and intimidating warriors. They relish in battle and shedding the blood of their enemies, and can easily close in on their target in the blink of an eye.

TABAXI

The cat-folk known as Tabaxi hail from the jungles of Chult to the west. They are nomadic in nature, but some have come to the mainland to set up trading routes among the populated areas. They move with grace and speed, can see in the dark, and hone their claws into deadly weapons.

TIEFLING

Tieflings have only come to be “accepted” in society within the last handful of decades. Born with demon blood in their veins, they have usually been seen as freaks or outcasts, living in squalor and slums in most cases. Having demonic physical features (tails, horns, colored skin, etc.), they are easy to spot in a crowd. They tend to see others as threats, and are very slow to trust other races. They can also see in the dark like their demon ancestors. The blood that flows through them gives them different traits and magical abilities, based on what kind of demon they come from.

- **Asmodeus:** These tieflings use powers of fire and darkness to overtake their foes.
- **Baalzebul:** These tieflings coerce foes with powers of psychological warfare.
- **Dispater:** These tieflings make use of illusions and intrigue to gain the upper hand.
- **Fierna:** These tieflings charm and beguile their foes to hold power of them.
- **Glasya:** These tieflings use disguises and illusions to accomplish their grim goals.
- **Levistus:** These tieflings harness the powers of ice and darkness to wear down enemies.
- **Mammon:** These tieflings use magic to gain wealth and hold power over foes.
- **Mephistopheles:** These tieflings use offensive magic to annihilate foes.
- **Zariel:** These tieflings use infernal divine powers to strike down enemies.

TORTLE

Turtle are a long-lived wise race of turtle folk. They are strong in both physical capabilities and willpower. Their shell provides amazing protection to their bodies. They possess knowledge of the land and surviving off of it, and can defend themselves with sharp claws.

TRITON

The sea-dwelling Tritons are crusaders and protectors of the oceans. Their extreme living conditions hone their skills as warriors, and allow them magical abilities to control both the elements of air and water, as well as communicate with sea life.

YUAN-TI PUREBLOOD

The mystical Yuan-Ti are people blessed (or cursed, depending on your moral views) with powers from an ancient snake god. They have a penchant for blending into and infiltrating societies, and using the magical powers and defenses to overcome any obstacle.

CLASSES

Listed here are summaries of each of the classes' abilities and roles.

BARBARIAN

Main Stats: Strength, Constitution

Role: Damage, Defense

With destructive primal instincts, the barbarian is a powerhouse in combat. The ability to rage gives them extra strength while fighting, but can leave them winded afterward. Upon reaching level 3, a barbarian must choose a Path to follow:

- **Path of the Ancestral Guardian** - The spirits of great tribal leaders and warriors guide and assist a barbarian, even going so far as to materialize as a combat ally.
- **Path of the Battlerager** - Utilizing spiked armor, they vie to destroy anything and anyone in their path. Their rage is so powerful, it can heal them as they fight.
- **Path of the Berserker** - When enraged, a barbarian loses himself completely and gives into pure carnal instinct to survive.
- **Path of the Storm Herald** - The great gods of the sky bestow power and energy into a barbarian, allowing them to affect those around them, and utilize those powers in many different ways and situations.
- **Path of the Zealot** - When a barbarian devotes their entire existence to a god, they can become an unstoppable force of divine energy bent on destroying their foes.

BARD

Main Stats: Charisma

Role: Buff, Control, Social, Stealth, Utility

As a veritable "Jack of All Trades", the bard can adapt their magic and abilities to any challenge. They expertly utilize their performances to inspire allies and distract foes. Upon reaching level 3, a bard must choose a College of study:

- **College of Glamour** - As a master of entrancing and enchanting, a bard can embolden allies and control their enemies' minds.
- **College of Lore** - A bard's best ability is performing, and what better way than to captivate a crowd with a fantastic tale of history and fantasy rolled into one. Their knowledge of the world can be utilized to psychically harm foes, and even learn spells from other classes.
- **College of Swords** - Just as quick as a bard's wit can be their blade. They can wield a weapon with elegance, and confuse their enemies with brilliant displays of swordplay.
- **College of Valor** - As a student of the art of combat, a bard can use their abilities to empower their allies while remaining a threat themselves.
- **College of Whispers** - A bard of this college knows just what secrets to blackmail an enemy with to get them to cooperate. They can even use these words to physically and psychologically harm their foes.

CLERIC

Main Stats: Wisdom

Role: Buff, Defense, Healing

In a world as varied as the many gods that watch over it, the devotees of these gods live to serve.

Using special magical abilities granted to them by their god, a cleric can empower, heal, harm, protect, and fight in the name of divinity. Upon reaching level 3, a cleric must choose a domain to follow:

- **Arcana Domain** - Seeking answers from gods through magical means, a cleric can learn magic far beyond their normal capabilities.
- **Death Domain** - Death is but another stage of life, and a cleric can use that to great effectiveness, harnessing divine magics to create lesser warriors of rotting flesh or call upon unholy powers to vanquish foes.
- **Forge Domain** - A cleric may view weapons and armor as the ultimate way to fight and protect. Following this domain allows a cleric to create and imbue weapons with extra power during combat.
- **Grave Domain** - Balance is of utmost importance to a cleric of this domain. They do not fear death, and instead try to bring wrath down upon those who would disturb the delicate balance between life and death and use it for their own gain.
- **Knowledge Domain** - For a cleric who seeks to grow as an individual, or to broaden their order's understanding of the world, knowledge is paramount. Granted the ability to delve into the minds of others, this cleric can learn all kinds of new things.
- **Life Domain** - A cleric is a savior of the sick and infirmed, and this domain grants them increased ability over the powers of life.
- **Light Domain** - A cleric devoted to good spends their life fighting a war against darkness. A cleric's spells can destroy minions of evil and light the way for others to follow them.
- **Nature Domain** - With help from nature's creatures and plants, a cleric can call on the powers of the natural world to help allies and overcome foes.
- **Tempest Domain** - Serving the gods of storms and weather, a cleric can call upon destructive forces to lay ruin to anything in their path.
- **Trickery Domain** - A cleric looking to infiltrate enemy lines, or distract and confuse enemies with intricate illusions, may find use in devoting themselves to this domain.
- **War Domain** - Nothing stirs the hearts of warriors like a blessing from the gods of battle. A cleric can inspire courage and aid allies with spells and weapons on the battlefield.

DRUID

Main Stats: Wisdom

Role: Control, Damage, Defense, Healing

A warrior in the service of nature, a druid calls on powers of the land, sky, sea, and animals to help in whatever way they can. They have the special ability to shapeshift into beasts of the wilds. Upon reaching level 3, a druid must select a Circle to serve:

- **Circle of Dreams** - With a special link to the Feywild, a druid can specialize in dream-walking and summoning creatures from other realms of existence.
- **Circle of the Land** - A druid of this circle devotes themselves to a type of terrain, and gains special spells and benefits associated with that terrain.
- **Circle of the Moon** - This circle allows a druid to master the skill of shapeshifting, increasing the size, type, and variety of creatures they can become as they train.
- **Circle of the Shepherd** - The many creatures and spirits of nature await a druid's call to aid in any situation. They choose a spirit animal to aid them, and can summon other creatures for help.

FIGHTER

Main Stats: Strength, Dexterity, Constitution

Role: Damage, Defense

Fighters train for one thing only: battle. They are adept at using a multitude of weapons, and have a wide range of skills and abilities that can help them gain the upper hand against enemies. Upon reaching level 3, a fighter must choose a Martial Archetype:

- **Arcane Archer** - Taught by skilled elven archers, this fighter utilizes a combination of ranged weapons and magic to inflict pain and suffering.
- **Battle Master** - As a skilled tactician, a fighter can react to a moment's notice and turn an enemies blunder into their own success.
- **Cavalier** - This fighter is trained in the art of mounted combat, learning skills to use their mount and weapons as one.
- **Champion** - Gladiators and pit fighters seek glory, and none moreso than this fighter. They know their way around many weapons, and can exploit enemies' weakness with great success.
- **Eldritch Knight** - Given special magical abilities by otherworldly powers, a fighter focuses their skill with a particular weapon, and can use it to great advantage over others.
- **Purple Dragon Knight** - The pinnacle of knighthood lies in this elite group. They are known throughout the land as lawkeepers and protectors of the realms. Through devotion, they gain a few special abilities some believe to be magical.
- **Samurai** - Skilled, calm warriors like this fighter study their enemies, and know the exact place and moment to strike like a whirlwind.

MONK

Main Stats: Dexterity, Wisdom

Role: Damage, Defense

Monks are devotees of martial arts, preferring to reflect on ones' self and surroundings to find peace and purpose in adventuring. They can use their inner Ki energy to enact impressive feats of prowess, sometimes as if they could cast magic. Upon reaching level 3, a monk must choose a Monastic Tradition to follow:

- **Way of the Drunken Master** - This monk loves ale just as much as fighting. While imbibing, they gain special abilities that seem to focus them, rather than incapacitate them.
- **Way of the Four Elements** - Through a connection with nature, a monk can harness the power of the elemental planes and cast spells with their Ki energy.
- **Way of the Kensei** - Training with weapons as if they are extensions of their body allows a monk to fight with them as if they contained magical power.
- **Way of the Long Death** - Death does not scare a monk. They train to harness its energies and are able to steal enemies' life essences while fighting them.
- **Way of the Open Hand** - This path leads a monk to hone their fists, limbs, and feet as fierce weapons capable of blinding speeds.
- **Way of the Shadow** - This monk utilizes the shadows around them, along with magical abilities and spells, to disappear and reappear and assassinate their enemies.
- **Way of the Sun Soul** - Life energy is a monk's most powerful weapon. Using their own life force, they can expel radiant energy for a variety of uses.

PALADIN

Main Stats: Strength, Dexterity, Charisma

Role: Damage, Defense, Healing

A paladin is a noble warrior or knight who sets forth to make the world a better place, based on their moral code and edicts they have been taught. They possess some magical abilities offered by their devotion, and are skilled combatants. Upon reaching level 3, a paladin must choose a Sacred Oath to lead them on their journey:

- **Oath of the Ancients** - Tenets of good are important to a paladin. With the powers of nature and light, a paladin can use them to maintain justice and stop evildoers.
- **Oath of Conquest** - Rules must be obeyed, and a paladin is there to make sure this happens. The paladin uses intimidation tactics to overpower their enemies.
- **Oath of the Crown** - A paladin sworn to protect the kingdom and its people must always remain a pinnacle of truth and justice. Those that seek to undermine this are met with swift action. As beacons of purity, they are able to inspire others to help them.
- **Oath of Devotion** - This paladin swears their life to protect the weak and oppressed, using their powers to magically protect others and smite enemies. They don't seek to destroy; only those truly deserving of death are dealt with to the extreme.
- **Oath of Vengeance** - A paladin in this oath swears vengeance on some individual or group that has slighted them in some way. They do anything they can to eliminate their mark, and can track them by magical means.
- **Oathbreaker** - This paladin has forsaken their vows and tenets, and found solace in unlife. They summon undead creatures, harness nefarious magics, and seek to become the ruler of all, both alive and dead.

RANGER

Main Stats: Dexterity, Wisdom

Role: Damage, Stealth

Rangers are master explorers and trackers. They blend in incredibly well in many different types of terrain, and can utilize skills of survival to take opponents by surprise. Focusing on lighter or ranged weapons, they take down their targets with skill and speed. Their connection to nature also allows them some magical abilities. Upon reaching level 3, a ranger must select a Ranger Archetype to continue honing their skills:

- **Beast Master** - A ranger can gain a helpful companion in the form of a fierce creature of nature. This beast grows and learns abilities as the ranger does, and can give a huge advantage as another fighter while adventuring.
- **Gloom Stalker** - Ambushing and stalking from shadows of night are this ranger's specialty. They excel at taking out foes from distances with deadly force.
- **Horizon Walker** - The ability to travel, whether by disappearing and reappearing nearby, or travelling to another plane of existence, is key to this archetype. A ranger can utilize this ability to catch their opponents by complete surprise. It can also be used to learn about dangers at these places, and prevent others from exploiting them.
- **Hunter** - Impeccable tracking and killing skills make this ranger a deadly foe. They specialize in hunting targets both individually and in groups, and can evade danger and detection if things go wrong on the hunt.
- **Monster Slayer** - These rangers excel at marking, stalking, and killing a single foe at a time. With abilities that isolate and focus on their target, they can take large or powerful enemies down in a matter of minutes.

ROGUE

Main Stats: Dexterity

Role: Damage, Utility, Social, Stealth

Rogues are tricksters, plain and simple. Using a variety of skills and abilities, they can cleverly hide or blend in with a snap of their fingers. Utilizing quick thinking and sharp weapons, they are excellent at neutralizing enemies, traps, and locks. Upon reaching level 3, a rogue must choose a Roguish

Archetype to follow:

- **Arcane Trickster** - Using magical means, the rogue can distract and stupefy their foes to gain an advantage and close in for the kill.
- **Assassin** - The rogue of this path specializes in remaining hidden until the exact right time to strike. With swift, deadly aim, the rogue can slay their opponents before they even realize what has happened.
- **Inquisitive** - A rogue that sneaks and skulks around can sometimes use this to their advantage, finding clues and tells that lead them to their target where others may get lost and confused. A detective of sorts, the rogue can study opponents and learn more about their weaknesses in the heat of battle.
- **Mastermind** - Cool and tactically active, a rogue can use manipulation tactics to get an enemy right where they want them.
- **Scout** - Rogues are adept at spotting trouble and danger ahead of others, and this path allows them to move quick and focused to a goal, all while keeping themselves and their allies out of harm's way.
- **Swashbuckler** - Grace and acrobatics are the forefront of a rogue's set of skills. This path trains them to fight on uneven or moving surfaces. The skill and performance of their combat tactics is almost like a dance.
- **Thief** - Infiltration, stealth, and extraction are paramount to a rogue's success and personal gain. With increased knowledge of how mechanisms like locks and traps work, and a penchant for unconventional means of entry and exit, it is rare that a rogue is caught off guard while attempting to steal a valuable treasure.

SORCERER

Main Stats: Constitution, Charisma

Role: Buff, Damage, Social

Sorcerers are powerful spellcasters whose power comes from deep within themselves and their lineage. They are able to tap into this power for extra magic not readily available to others. They also possess the powers to bend magic to their will, altering its properties as they see fit for any situation. Starting at level 1, a Sorcerer taps into their lineage by learning and focusing their Sorcerous Origin:

- **Divine Soul** - blessed with magic from the gods, a sorcerer can cast spells similar to that of a cleric or paladin, aiding and healing others as well as dealing devastation to enemies.
- **Draconic Bloodline** - Somewhere in their heritage was a dragon or dragonborn. By accessing this monstrous power, a sorcerer undergoes a physical transformation. It improves their spells' power, gives them extra abilities, and protect you in dire times.
- **Shadow Magic** - The dark arts run strong in a sorcerer's bloodline. The powers of darkness and death can be instruments of destruction in the right (or wrong) hands. They also have the power to stave off death, should it loom on the horizon.
- **Storm Sorcery** - Natural phenomena and disasters are some of the most powerful forces, and a sorcerer can feel this power within themselves. Harnessing elemental force and destruction, the skies and weather bend to their will.
- **Wild Magic** - The power in a sorcerer's bloodline cannot always be controlled. Sometimes tapping too deep too quickly can cause unseen consequences. When magic takes over and follows its own path, the effects can be equally wondrous and catastrophic.

WARLOCK

Main Stats: Constitution, Charisma

Role: Control, Damage

Warlocks are spellcasters whose abilities have been granted through a pact with a greater entity. The gift of power comes in many forms, but they all share a common bond: the entity that gives this power always wants something in return, and the warlock must be able to pay the price. Starting at level 1, a warlock is granted power by an Otherworldly Patron:

- **The Archfey** - The warlock has made a pact with a powerful fey lord from the Feywild. Granted powers of enchanting, disguising, and beguiling, the warlock can control and command both friends and foes alike.
- **The Celestial** - Sometimes the gods and their servants bargain with mortals to stop a great power in the world. The abilities granted a warlock from a celestial patron rival those of the cleric and paladin, with healing and destructive forces imbued with divine energy.
- **The Fiend** - Pacts and trades are common among demons and devils, and a warlock is often promised immense power in return for extremely valuable things these creatures crave. The powers given to them tend to be extremely destructive.
- **The Great Old One** - There exist in various realms beings older than time itself. They slumber in the farthest reaches of the universe, and begin to awaken and gain followers in the form of warlocks who devote themselves to the entity. Their power is unimaginable, and often materializes in curses, madness, and psychic abilities.
- **The Hexblade** - The warlock's primary power comes from a powerful magic weapon bestowed upon them by a god. This weapon grants a number of special combat abilities, and can be hidden from plain view and revealed in the blink of an eye.
- **The Undying** - Death and afterlife are merely another part of the warlock's patron's journey. Granted powers over life and death, a warlock can bring slain back to walk among the living, amass armies of undead hordes, and spread disease and contagion like wildfire.

WIZARD

Main Stats: Intelligence

Role: Buff, Control, Damage, Utility

Wizards spend lifetimes studying the intricacies and utilities of magic. With great tomes of spells and knowledge, they use a variety of spells and powers to accomplish all kinds of goals. With a greater understanding of magic than any other class, they can become forces to be reckoned with. Upon reaching level 2, a wizard must choose an Arcane Tradition to specialize in:

- **Bladesinger** - Combat and spells are weaved hand in hand with this style. Using ancient elven magics, a wizard enters a trance and becomes a whirlwind of destruction.
- **School of Abjuration** - Abjuration magic protects the wizard and their allies with defense and deflection.
- **School of Conjuration** - Summoning minions and objects to fight and aid the wizard is the central teaching of this path.
- **School of Divination** - Seeing into the past and future can give anyone the upper hand, and a wizard who can do both can become a deadly foe.
- **School of Enchantment** - Wizards are able to convince and coerce (magically) those that would stand in their way or do them harm.
- **School of Evocation** - Mastering the art of destruction and devastation is difficult and dangerous, but wizards are extremely skilled at it. They can even learn to keep their allies safe from such danger while in the throes of combat.
- **School of Illusion** - Smoke and mirrors can be incredibly effective in subverting enemies, and a wizard is adept at producing both illusions and hallucinations to distract foes.
- **School of Necromancy** - The forces of life and death become malleable clay to a wizard. Harnessing dark energies and creating walking dead minions makes them fearsome and dangerous.
- **School of Transmutation** - Changing the physical properties of the world around them, a wizard can become masters of creation and adapt to any situation, even transforming allies and enemies into other creatures.
- **War Magic** - Disciplined and tactically learned, a wizard can change the tide of battle in an instant with a variety of powerful spells, focused in the schools of Abjuration and Evocation.

ABILITY SCORES

Ability scores are the values that define your character's physical and mental capabilities. Here are brief descriptions of each of the six abilities.

STRENGTH

Strength measures your natural athleticism and physical power. It affects melee attacks in combat, and how much damage you deal with them.

DEXTERITY

Dexterity measures your reflexes, agility, and balance. It affects ranged attacks in combat, and how much damage you deal with them. It also affects your armor class and defenses, as well as how quickly you react to threats of battle.

CONSTITUTION

Constitution measures your health, stamina, and vitality. It affects how many hit points you have, as well as your ability to resist disease and poison.

INTELLIGENCE

Intelligence measures analytical skill, mental capacity, and memory. It affects some spellcaster's ability to use magic.

WISDOM

Wisdom measures your awareness and intuition. It affects some spellcaster's ability to use magic.

CHARISMA

Charisma measures your confidence, eloquence, and outward personality. It affects some spellcaster's ability to use magic.

ROLLING ABILITY SCORES

The method I use to determine ability scores is as follows:

1. Roll 4d6 dice. Disregard the lowest number rolled, and add the other three together. (Ex: You rolled 4, 5, 2, and 3. Since 2 is the lowest number rolled, it is disregarded, and the other numbers are totalled, for a total score of 12. NOTE: If the lowest number is shown on two dice, only disregard one of the dice.)
2. Repeat step 1 five more times, for a total of six scores.
3. Assign these six scores into the six abilities listed above. Take into account your class and its main stats.
4. Apply the ability score changes determined by your race.

CHARACTER DESCRIPTION

While most of the description and motivations of your character are completely up to you, there is a part that can help you focus in your vision. These are called Backgrounds. The following list is a brief summary of the backgrounds available to all characters. They give you extra skills, equipment, and a special ability.

ACOLYTE

You have spent your life in the service of a temple, religion, or specific god. You know how to perform sacred rites and offer worship services to those in need. You can seek aid, healing, and shelter from those that share your faith.

CHARLATAN

You know how to talk to people and get things from them without doing any of the work. Your powers of persuasion, albeit deceitful, have gotten you far in life. You have a second identity, complete with documentation, acquaintances, and disguises. Additionally, you can expertly forge official papers and personal letters, provided you have seen a reference of the work or handwriting.

CRIMINAL

You have spent long years in the service and company of criminals and their organizations. You have reliable contacts with criminal networks around the area who can act as liaisons for you. You know how to secretly contact them, and how to exploit the local corrupt merchants and officials.

ENTERTAINER

Giving people a show is your favorite hobby. Through song, dance, music, poetry, or story, you have captivated audiences for many years. You can always find a place to perform your art, like an inn. You receive free lodging and food as long as you perform each night you intend to stay. Additionally, locals tend to take a liking to you after seeing you perform.

FOLK HERO

You are regarded in your homeland as somewhat of a hero by moderate means. Common folk in any location hold you with esteem, and they will provide you with anything you need (within reason).

GUILD ARTISAN

You are a member of an artisan's guild and make fine crafts to use and sell. Your guild membership will gain you access to others' workshops, as well as food and lodging. If you are in trouble, your guild may come to your aid, as they wouldn't want their reputation tarnished. Guild membership does have fees of 5 gp per month.

HERMIT

You have lived in seclusion or a tight community for most of formative life. The quiet, solitude, and time away from society have given you a fresh perspective on life. You have discovered a great secret of life, the land, or the cosmos, and some may benefit or be corrupted by such knowledge. (Work with your DM to determine what this knowledge is.)

NOBLE

You grew up in a wealthy family, surrounded by the smartest, most influential, and richest folk in the land. Thanks to that upbringing, you are welcome in high society in lands far and wide. Common folk make every effort to accommodate your requests, and local nobles will offer you audience to discuss matters of importance.

OUTLANDER

You grew up in the wilds of the forests, mountains, or plains, far from established civilization. You have an excellent memory for geography and maps, and can expertly recall landmarks and features in the area around you. Additionally, you can successfully gather supplies like food and water while in the wilderness for you and up to five other individuals each day.

SAGE

You have spent years studying the multiverse, pouring over tomes, scrolls, and manuscripts to uncover its infinite secrets. You are considered a master in your field of study. When you try to recall information on a piece of lore, you know exactly where to go and who to talk to in order to find the answer, if you don't already know it.

SAILOR

You've spent many years on ships, learning much of the ways of the sky and sea. You can always find passage on a ship for yourself and your companions, though you are expected to assist in the needs of the ship in exchange.

SOLDIER

You served for some years in the local militia or great military. The regimental training has honed your abilities. Your military rank affords you authority and influence in many areas. You can use your rank to command other soldiers in lower ranks than you, and you can acquire equipment and horses for temporary use. Military fortresses and camps will often grant you access and respite if your rank is recognized in their army.

URCHIN

Your life has been hard: stealing to survive, living on the street, running from authorities. You've done remarkable well to survive this long. You can quickly discern any secret patterns, passages, and flows to a city's layout, and can travel twice as fast through a city when not in combat.

FINISHING UP

EQUIPMENT

Your equipment is mostly determined by your class and background. If you have any special requests, let me know and I will discuss them with you.

NUMBER CRUNCHING

After you've chosen your equipment, we'll crunch all the formulas, for things such as attacks, damage, hit points, initiative, etc.

SPELLS

If you are a spellcaster, we will go over how that works, what spells you have at your disposal, and how to choose what you cast during your adventures.